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Revisiting media richness theory for today and future

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Abstract

Media richness theory was developed in the mid-1980s in the field of business management and became very popular along with the diffusion of electronic communication media. Despite the popularity, inconsistent results from empirical studies have been the issues with this theory. In addition, the recent advanced communication technology has been raising more challenges towards the original concepts. Thus, we have reviewed the literature in the past decade to illustrate diverse applications and validity of the theory with more recent communication channels. Based on the findings we have also discussed a future of media richness theory.

KEYWORDS

application, communication technology, media richness theory, validity

1 | MEDIA RICHNESS THEORY

Media richness theory was developed in the mid-1980s by organizational scholars, Daft and Lengel (and later with Trevino) and became very popular along with the diffusion of electronic communication media (e.g., email in 1990s). The theory suggests the effective use of a communication channel (medium) by matching the richness of a medium and the equivocality of task. Daft and Lengel (1984, 1986) paid attention to the significance of uncertainty and equivocality reduction in successful information processing in organizations. More specifically, uncertainty is the lack of information, which can be reduced by the quantity or amount of information. In contrast, equivocality refers to confusion or lack of understanding, which cannot be reduced by the amount of information but can be reduced by the quality or richness of information (Daft, Lengel, & Trevino, 1987). In a mediated situation using a communication technology such as email, uncertainty reduction would not be the problem because technology can carry a large amount of information to reduce uncertainty. Equivocality reduction, on the other hand, would be problematic primarily due to the lack of nonverbal cues inherent in mediated communication. Thus, the theory determines the "richness" of a medium based on availability of: (a) immediate feedback, (b) multiple cues, (c) language variety, and (d) personal focus. Based on these four criteria, the original theory ranked face-to-face as the richest medium, followed by phone, written addressed document (e.g., memo, letter), and unaddressed document (e.g., flyer). Thus, for a high level of an equivocal task, such as an explanation of a complicate technical matter, face-to-face, the richest medium, would be most effective. Whereas for a low level of an equivocal task, such as giving numerical data requested, a lean medium (e.g., an unaddressed document) would be most effective. The most important premise from the authors, which is often overlooked by the audience, is that effective managers can select the most appropriate medium by successfully matching the richness of a medium to the level of equivocality of the task (Daft et al., 1987).

1.1 | From objective to subjective views towards media richness

As described above, media richness theory derived from an objective view of media characteristics, and thus, the use of a particular medium is objectively determined. However, due to inconsistent results from empirical studies, researchers started discussing more factors related to an individual media use. These researchers have supported subjective views of media use. For example, the social information processing model of media use posits that media use behavior is not determined only by the objective media characteristics, but also socially influenced by multiple factors including attitudes towards the particular medium, personal experience, knowledge about the medium, and so on (Fulk, Steinfield, Schmitz, & Power, 1987). Most importantly, social information available in the workplace, specifically

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information from an immediate supervisor and coworkers, (Fulk, 1993; Fulk et al., 1987) affects the perception towards the media richness, equivocality of task, attitudes towards the particular medium, and the use of a particular medium. For example, if the user's supervisor perceives email as the richest, although it is retrospectively ranked less rich than face-to-face and phone based on the four evaluation criteria of richness, and uses email for conflict management (a high level of equivocality), the individual is most likely to use email for conflict management influenced by his/her supervisor. This behavior contradicts media richness theory.

In fact, Trevino, Daft, and Lengel (1990) also consider a subjective factor and discuss how each medium represents a "symbol" in an organization. For example, an addressed letter on the organization's letterhead represents formality, and the use of email (or texting today) represents urgency. Thus, the authors have added the involvement of media symbolism to media richness theory as the third factor in selecting the most appropriate medium.

Considering this in reality, later theories/models address more subjective views towards the media use behavior. Sitkin, Sutcliffe, and Barrios-Choplin (1992) posit that a medium can carry both data and symbols in their dual capacity model. They further discuss how the symbolic meaning of each medium is derived from organizational culture, which is also an important factor in the use of a particular medium. For example, in one organization, a formal hiring letter on the organization's letterhead is mailed out to the job interviewee, which carries a symbol of formality for the important notice. In another organization, a phone call is made to the job interviewee for the hiring decision. In this case, phone carries a symbol of personal touch for the important notice. In short, these different behaviors are influenced by their organizational culture that directs how to use a particular medium based on written or unwritten rules.

Furthermore, Carlson and Zmud (1999) have extended media richness theory by adding the significance of social influence and individual experience on perceived media richness. Their channel expansion theory also discusses subjective views towards media richness because individual perception of media richness is influenced by social information as well as personal experience. They further specified types of experience into four categories: (a) experience with a particular channel, (b) experience with a particular topic, (c) experience with a particular communicator, and (d) experience with particular organizational contexts. When testing these four types of experience, empirical studies partially supported this theory (e.g., Timmerman & Madhavapeddi, 2008), yet experience with the medium has been a predictor of perceived media richness. For example, Ishii's (2005) study on email use among university administrators showed that those who were more experienced with email were more likely to use email, even for equivocal tasks. In addition, those who have more experience with email showed a higher level of communication satisfaction with supervisors even for equivocal tasks. It seems that these findings reflect the use of text-messaging today. We often see the use of texting for any purpose, particularly among I-generations who were born and grew up with communication technologies.

Another improvement of media richness theory was the consideration of the valence of message in selecting a communication channel. Sheer and Chen (2004) found that managers follow the theory's suggested matching in selecting the most appropriate channel for positive messages. For negative messages, however, an individual presentation goal is more important than the level of equivocality due to their anxiety inherent in the negative messages. Likewise, since media richness theory has become popular in early 1990s, abundant researchers have discussed the involvement of various factors such as accessibility, competency in use, time and cost saving, impression management, at the individual level (see Rice & Leonardi, 2014).

2 | EMPIRICAL STUDIES IN THE PAST DECADE

Along with the advancement of technology, various communication channels have become available. Constantly evolving technology, specifically, the rapid diffusion of mobile devices, has significantly altered communication in recent years. It has, thus, opened doors for potential areas of study. The use of a particular channel and its outcomes has been the interest of many scholars and practitioners, and we see a plethora of research in diverse contexts. Despite criticisms of the oversimplified channel selection, media richness theory has become salient to almost all areas of life since its impetus several decades ago.

In the following sections, we review empirical studies in the past decade to illustrate the theory's (a) application (i.e., extended fields to which the theory has been applied) and (b) validity (i.e., support and challenges of the theory) with recent communication channels. Addressing these two issues, we discuss important findings from past studies in the order of interpersonal, educational, and organizational contexts.

2.1 | Interpersonal context

An inappropriate channel selection for the message may damage the relationship (Ledbetter, 2014), yet the increase of channel options may give pressure to users on what is deemed a morally or socially appropriate way to transmit a message to another individual (Madianou & Miller, 2012). Perhaps for these reasons, one of the most extended areas of research on media richness theory is about interpersonal relationships. For example, in Pettegrew and Day's (2015) study, 79% of participants reported that mobile devices have changed communication in interpersonal relationships. Reflecting the alteration, numerous studies have examined the role of communication in the development of friendships with media richness theory.

Recently diffused communication media such as webcam, instant messaging, texting and social media would be placed as leaner channels than face-to-face communication based on the four criteria outlined in media richness theory. Examining the association between duration of interaction and happiness as the outcome over a variety of recent channels, Vlahovic, Roberts, and Dunbar's (2012) study still reported the significance of face-to-face communication among

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others. The result exhibited that increases in duration of interaction was a positive predictor of happiness only for face-to-face communication, and for learner channels, such as texting, telephone, and email, duration of interaction had no relationship with happiness.

Kwak (2012), however, argued online media could be either lean or rich depending on the communicator media use. For example, voice chat was considered a rich channel by allowing immediate feedback, which was used for equivocal communication. In addition, communicator motive is involved in a selection of channels. For instance, an active motive for communication led to use a richer channel (e.g., voice chat), whereas passive motive drove to a leaner channel (e.g., text-based chat).

The literature also discusses that recent advanced technology has been enriching "lean" channels that are used in relationship development. For example, Sheer's studies (2010, 2011) reported that adolescents in Hong Kong liked using instant messaging (e.g., MSN, ICQ) with the attached audio and video features. In addition, unlike synchronous channels (e.g., face-to-face), adolescents liked the advanced tool of "presentation control" in the asynchronous channel. The tool allowed users to portray a self-selected, desirable image by filtering or regulating information in messages, pictures, and videos. Using the features adolescents perceive instant messaging relatively rich. The use of the relatively rich channel could control the quality of communication, which, in turn, contributed to friendship quality (Sheer, 2010).

In her following study, Sheer (2011) reported the significance of lean media catering to different types of relationships. More specifically, the advanced features of webcam that could carry multiple cues (e.g., visual and auditory cues) and control self-presentation helped display a desirable self-image in the embryonic stages of friendships and increased the number of friends. However, it was the lean text that have developed close friendships allowing adolescents to exchange their personal, in-depth thoughts.

The interactivity in text also contributed to the development and maintenance of friendships using more recent media such as text-based social media (Zhou, Su, Zhou, & Zhang, 2016) and mobile-phone based texting (Liu & Yang, 2016). Liu and Yang's study also revealed that the accessibility of mobile phones facilitated immediate communication in close friendships. In contrast, internet-dependent social networking sites, including instant messaging services on the sites, were used in less intimate relationships. Although text messaging is considered a lean channel by the criteria in media richness theory, texting from a mobile phone without Internet access was used more frequently in close relationships that would expect immediate responses (Liu & Yang, 2016). These studies unveil that users have become adept at using the text-based lean channel taking advantage of the advanced technology in the context of interpersonal communication.

2.2 | Educational context

The advanced communication technology is also available in education. The technology is used not only in traditional classrooms, but also in online classrooms, communication between teachers/students, and even between teachers and students' parents outside of the classroom. Media richness theory has been applied to determine if a particular channel is more or less effective than others in the learning environment.

Mobile learning is an important, growing topic of interest in education. Adding accuracy and adaptability to the criteria of media richness, Lan and Sie (2010) compared three media: (a) really simple syndication (RSS) (b) email, and (c) short message service (SMS) to investigate the successful disbursement of educational information in mobile learning. Their findings demonstrated that email was the content richest channel, which was best suited for carrying quantities of information to give detail. However, SMS or text messaging was superior in terms of timeliness. Furthermore, RSS, which could instantly inform the subscribers the information updates, was superior in terms of accuracy and adaptability. Based on these results, the study concluded that RSS was most appropriate for mobile-learning device. These findings indicated that each channel had advantages in different areas.

In fact, an increasing number of online courses in education has gained attention from researchers and teachers. In particular, student outcomes from online courses have been their interests. For instance, Lan, Hung, and Hsu (2011) compared motivation, anxiety, and enjoyment of writing tasks among elementary students in a traditional classroom and two levels of a computer mediated classroom (i.e., rich and lean). The rich online condition provided images, multiuser function, and life-like quality simulations. On the other hand, the lean online condition was text-based with the option for the participants to perform suggested word searches. The nononline, face-to-face condition (theoretically richest) was verbally led by an instructor with pen and paper directions. There was no multiuser function available in the traditional setting. This study reported that directions using the rich mediated channel was best suited for anxiety reduction and enjoyment of the writing task. However, there was no significant difference in motivation between the rich and lean online channels. Directions using the rich and lean mediated channels were better than the traditional pen and paper method to enhance motivation in the participants. Based on these findings, the authors concluded that the rich online classroom was overall the superior choice for students to become successful writers.

Discussion is one of the popular assignments in online courses. Balaji and Chakrabarti (2010) studied the role of online discussion forums in a traditional face-to-face course. Despite the leaner characteristics of online discussion, compared to face-to-face discussion, online discussion is considered a more active approach than the traditional lecture-only style. Their results revealed that interactivity was effective in online learning. In addition, the use of multiple channels (i.e., face-to-face and online) led to better student performance by taking technological advantages of each channel. A consistent result was reported in Brinker, Gastil, and Richards's (2015) study on online civic education (e.g., deliberative, political discussions). They found the use of multiple channels of varying richness was more effective in reaching audiences who had different levels of knowledge concerning

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online civic engagement. Media channels such as video and text were more effective in expanding educational knowledge, whereas video chat aided in participants' ability to build social ties and formulate persuasive arguments. Thus, they suggested the use of multiple channels would effectively achieve different educational purposes and goals.

However, a high dropout rate has been observed in online courses. This serious issue in higher education became the rationale of Cole's (2016) study. The results essentially supported media richness theory by indicating that students showed higher satisfaction with face-to-face than online courses. In addition, students tended to be more satisfied with face-to-face communication with the instructor and classmates than online communication with them. Furthermore, student satisfaction with online communication with the instructor and classmates positively contributed to online course satisfaction. However, there was no relationship between the satisfaction with face-to-face communication and online course satisfaction. As media richness theory suggests that rich media are not always effective by stressing the significance of "matching" between the level of media richness and equivocality in communication tasks, this study also shows that communication with rich media may not always produce positive outcomes.

As introduced earlier, K-12 teachers have also been communicating with students' parents. For certain types of sensitive topics (e.g., child's health and behavior), parents preferred richer media (e.g., face-to-face) that allowed immediate feedback and natural conversations. However, parents were most likely to choose email to discuss their child with teachers, including their academic performance, because many parents perceived the asynchronous nature of email was effective for communication with busy teachers (Thompson & Mazer, 2012). Their following study also reported that email was most frequently selected by parents to communicate with teachers even for equivocal conversations for certain reasons. For example, some parents perceive email as convenient because it allows easy access from their smartphones while they are waiting for their child's after school activity in the car. In addition, the asynchronous nature of email allows parents to better articulate a message, which facilitates more effective communication with teachers (Thompson, Mazer, & Flood Grady, 2015). These studies demonstrated the recent use of "rich" and "lean" channels in the educational context and suggested the significant involvement of contextual factors rather than equivocality in communication when selecting a particular channel.

2.3 | Organizational context

As discussed earlier, media richness theory was born in an organizational setting and has continued to inspire new research within the context of organizations and managerial practices. Yet, studies in this context have also shown inconsistent results. For example, Braun, Hernandez Bark, Kirchner, Stegmann, and van Dick (2019) examined ideal managerial communication of employees. They compared it to the actual communication practices in the workplace. Although there is a trend towards more frequent computer-mediated communication than face-to-face communication in the workplace, employees may not perceive that the use of "lean" media leads to effective leadership communication. The results indeed reported that many employees expected the use of richer channels, such as face-to-face, communication and expected less use of lean channels, such as telephone/email, by their managers. Supporting media richness theory, Braun et al. (2019) also found an association between the use of richer channels by leaders and positive perceptions towards the leader's effectiveness and personability.

Other studies more directly tested subjective perception towards media richness. Armengol, Fernandez, Simo, and Sallan (2017) compared supervisor communicative behavior (e.g., informing, listening, and coordinating) to peer behavior via email to investigate social influence on an individual perception towards the richness of email. Their results were inconsistent with Fulk's (1993) study and exhibited that social influence on perceived media richness was significant only from a manager but not from coworkers.

Successful collaboration among team members is significant to achieve organizational goals. Such collaboration often takes place online today. Aritz, Walker, and Cardon (2018) investigated how the teams collaborated using multiple, media-based communication channels, such as email, Google Docs, Facebook, texting, and phone calls. They also examined a team's preference for certain channels and communicative tools. Each of the channels used (e.g., file sharing, web conferencing, messaging, phone) was grouped into four categories based on the characteristics. For example, Google Docs and email were both considered to have file sharing capabilities, whereas texting and instant messaging were placed into the messaging category. Well-coordinated teams were more likely to use richer channels that allowed immediate feedback, such as web conferencing and phone than poorly-coordinated teams. In addition, compared to poorly-coordinated teams, well-coordinated teams viewed collaborative platforms such as Google Docs and Facebook as more effective for group communication than email. Media richness theory would list Google Docs and Facebook as leaner channels based on the four criteria outlined, yet their study revealed the significant effect of interactivity available in these leaner channels on the individual perception of media richness. The tools embedded in these channels allow social interactivity that leads to high rehearsability (i.e., preparation for final polished messages) and reprocessability (i.e., retrievability for processing over time). Thus, through interaction over these "lean" channels, team members can refine the original messages over time. After completing the task in virtual teamwork, participants reported that these lean yet interactive channels were effective for the team project online.

However, the contribution of interactivity to media richness is not always positive. In the realm of recruiting, Badger, Kaminsky, and Behrend (2014) examined the effectiveness of interactivity on online recruitment systems. The study compared a traditional website (a lean medium) to an interactive site created in a virtual platform (a rich medium), and the researchers discovered that job applicants could recall more factual information from the leaner, traditional website than the richer, interactive site. The authors discussed that the interactivity might have diverted attention from the information retrieval

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and concluded that richer media may not always be effective in the portrayal of organizational information and image for job applicants. Likewise, richer media do not always display helpful information from person to person. Apers and Derous (2017) found that the use of a richer channel to present job applicant resumes, such as video rather than the traditional paper, masked their personalities, which challenged recruiters who often judged from the resumes in the first place. However, Saat and Selamat's (2014) study on communication for corporate social responsibility still showed that richer websites with animation and videos than lean websites produced effective communication.

The inconsistent support for media richness theory was also apparent in a study on communication between suppliers and buyers of a new product. Similar to past studies that did not support the theory, Thomas (2013) found that the richest face-to-face communication and lean email exchanges had no difference in the level of knowledge exchange. However, this result might be influenced by the email strategies communicators used (e.g., speedy feedback, adaptable to circumstance, and language), especially when the participants were working closely together on a project. Furthermore, this study showed different advantages from the rich and lean media. More specifically, multiple cues available in face-to-face communication allow knowledge exchange among members easily, which is, in turn, viewed as effective for new product development. On the other hand, email can overcome time and space constraints reducing costs for face-to-face meetings in the process of knowledge exchange, which, in turn, makes product development more efficient. This finding would explain the recent use of multiple media among organizational members (e.g., Stephens, Barrett, & Mahometa, 2013) and among consumers (e.g., Maity, Dass, & Kumar, 2018)

Maity et al. (2018) discovered media richness involved in perceived cost in information-seeking behavior, which affected media use by consumers. Their results indicated that the richer the channel, the lower the cost of information-seeking because richer channels could automatically carry a large volume of information about the product that helped consumers' decisions. When the perceived cost of information-seeking was high, consumers were less likely to engage in information-seeking and relied on a richer medium from which they could retrieve information easily. However, active information-seeking behavior with a linear medium produced a positive outcome because consumers made an effort in information-seeking, and they were more likely to remember the information. As we discussed earlier, the effective use of rich or lean media also depends on the user motivation.

Based on the review of extant literature regarding media richness theory, it is evident that the theory has grown from its original premise of effective managerial communication to more inclusive to other aspects of communication, including interpersonal relationship, educational settings, and organizational practices. As our review shows, media richness theory has been vastly studied across the contexts, yet these studies have also shown discrepancies in the theory, particularly with more recent media. These studies reported more factors (e.g., communication motives, attached technical features in "lean" media, contextual factors) in selecting a particular channel.

3 | MEDIA RICHNESS THEORY IN FUTURE

Despite the popularity of media richness theory, researchers have acknowledged the involvement of multiple factors in media use behavior since the development of the theory in the mid-1980s, as discussed earlier. Our review of the literature with recent communication media also showed the inconsistent results concerning media richness across communication contexts, as we presented. Many people no longer consider the theory's suggestion for the best matching between the richness of a medium and the equivocality of communication task. In addition, earlier researchers (e.g., Carlson & Zmud, 1999; Fulk et al., 1987; Sitkin et al., 1992; Trevino et al., 1990) pointed out the effects of social influence, accessibility, experience with the medium, symbolic meaning (e.g., phone for immediacy), etc. in the selection of a particular channel. It seems that all of these subjective factors, technological advancements, and an increasing number of "tech savvy" people today alter the traditional objective concept of media richness theory.

Furthermore, our review attested that the constantly evolving technology has been enriching "lean" media in multiple ways and transforming communication. For example, the recent diffusion of mobile devices such as smartphones in a society has facilitated the "speed" and "convenience" of communication. Communicators have been taking technological advantages in different areas as their strategies for media use, which seem to facilitate the use of multiple channels. In addition, the embedded technological features in "lean" media often facilitates interactivity between communicators, which can make a significant contribution to perceived media richness. The significance of interactivity is not only among "tech savvy" young people who grew up with technology but also among the elderly. A recent study among users over 60 years old reported the significance of interactivity in communication with the medium (e.g., stickers, pictures, audio/videos) on an individual perception towards richness of a medium (Yang & Lin, 2019).

These studies, however, also indicate that users still attend to the significance of media characteristics. In fact, Ishii, Rife, and Kagawa (2017) discuss that text-messaging users seek technology-driven gratification. Their study among American and Japanese college students has revealed that both college students perceive text messaging as rich, if they seek technology-driven gratification. An interesting finding from this study is that these college students consider text messaging as an asynchronous channel, which can be interpreted that these users may not expect an immediate response by using text messaging. Yet, American college students perceive this text-based channel as rich because it can send a message any time at the user's convenience. Japanese students also report that text messaging as rich, although their primary reason is quick transmission of a message, which is slightly different from American students. These results from recent studies indicate that media richness today can be still discussed

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with the objective characteristics, yet media richness is subjectively based on how we use the channel, taking advantage of the characteristics of the advanced technology.

As discussed earlier, media richness theory has served as a building block for a multitude of theories, and we expect that this tendency will remain as more communication technologies continue to advance. In addition to the theories that we have already discussed, we will add two theories derived from media richness theory, which will continue to propel future research.

First, media synchronicity theory suggests the significance of media ability to support synchronicity, which refers to a shared pattern of coordinated behavior among work members (Dennis & Valacich, 1999). Building on this original concept, two communication processes of conveyance of information and convergence of understanding have enhanced the theory. The improved theory suggests that each medium has different capabilities in support for conveyance and convergence in terms of (a) immediacy of feedback, (b) parallelism, (c) symbol variety, (d) rehearsability, and (e) reprocessability (Dennis, Fuller, & Valacich, 2008). The theory has been supported by studies on the media use to transmit deceptive messages (George, Carlson, & Valacich, 2013) and global collaboration of software development projects (Niinimaki, Piri, Lassenius, & Paasivaara, 2012). As discussed earlier, recent media easily allow collaboration among communicators (Aritz et al., 2018), which significantly facilitates group projects that are common in many organizations. Thus, this theory has the potential to extend the research area of effective collaboration via communication technology.

Another theory, media multiplexity theory, was developed to better understand the link between relational tie strength and the number of media used to maintain a relationship (Haythornthwaite, 2002). Tie strength is concerned with the perceived closeness of a relationship and expressed as either a "weak" tie or "strong" tie. Although media richness theory does not address relational closeness between communicators in their media use behavior, Haythornthwaite (2002) suggests in this theory that the relational factor is a significant contributor in selecting a particular channel. This theory has influenced current research including a study on channel enjoyment as a motivator for media use in interpersonal communication (Ledbetter, Taylor, & Mazer, 2016) and research on media use in serial arguments (Pusateri, Roaché, & Ningxin, 2015). We believe that this theory continues to help enhance our understanding of relational communication as well as a recent trend of the use of multiple communication channels in a variety of contexts including between supervisor–subordinate, peers, teacher–student, friends, and family members.

4 | CONCLUSION

Our review of media richness theory has only shown some of research studies that were conducted in three communication contexts in the past decade. As we progressed, we have learned the significant influence of this theory on research studies around the world. Similar to other researchers, we have also acknowledged the limitations of the theory developed in 1980s, yet we believe that media richness theory remains the landmark foundation of studies on continuously evolving communication technology and media use behavior.

CONFLICT OF INTEREST

The authors declared no potential conflicts of interest.

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